

The Top Five Linux Distributions of 2013

It's that time of the year when making lists is fashionable. Here is one such list in which the top five Linux distros of last year are featured.

The beauty of open source lies in the diverse array of choices that one can make when selecting software or a particular tool. Unlike most other proprietary or closed source software, open source solutions do not tie you down to a particular product or entity. Instead, you are encouraged to take your pick from the multitude of offerings available, and then decide which one works best for you.

Similarly, when it comes to Linux distributions as well, you do not have to limit yourself to any particular one and give up on all others. As a Linux enthusiast myself, I often tend to switch distros just to try out something new, even though I often find myself coming back to Linux Mint and openSUSE. That said, to each his own, and hence almost every Linux distribution, big or small, has its own share of loyal followers.

In this article, I shall attempt to enumerate five of the best Linux distros of 2013. Once again, selecting a particular Linux distribution is a matter of individual preference, but I have tried to consider the distros' relative popularity and ease of use while ranking them (yet, pardon the bias please, for I am openly in favour of Linux Mint and openSUSE, above all others).

A note on the list

It is obviously not an easy task to single out five particular distros. There were many worthy names that had to be left out. For instance, the first 'honourable mention' should rightfully go to Debian, which serves as the parent distro for both Ubuntu and Linux Mint. However, considering the fact that both Ubuntu and Linux Mint have surpassed Debian in terms of their user

base, it only made sense to favour them over Debian.

Apart from Debian, there were certain other distros too that had to be omitted, simply because the others deserved their rankings more—Slackware, Gentoo Linux, Mageia, Sabayon and Arch Linux—all personal favourites of mine, but sadly, they couldn't make it to the top five.

Finally, considering the fact that this is more of a list about general-purpose Linux distros, those distributions that serve a specific need were not considered. For this very reason, you will not find CentOS on this page (it is more of an enterprise OS than a general-usage distro), nor ArtistX (meant for artists and creative heads), Red Hat Enterprise Linux (again, for enterprises), or Puppy Linux.

1. Ubuntu (and variants)

You just cannot talk about Linux distributions without mentioning Ubuntu in the same breath. In fact, in terms of popularity, Ubuntu beats almost all Linux distros.

Based on Debian,

